Although they inflicted a memorable defeat on General George Custer's 7th US Cavalry at the Battle of the Little Bighorn in June, 1876, the Plains Indians mostly fought a guerrilla-style war of small-scale raids and ambushes. The US used brutal but effective counterinsurgency tactics, attacking encampments and destroying food supplies.

The UK resorted to a similar strategy in the later stages of the Boer War of 1899–1902 (see pp.256–57), when the mounted Boer commandos turned to guerrilla warfare. Armed with Mauser magazine rifles, Creusot artillery, and Maxim guns, the Boers shocked the British Army out of its complacency. By the early 20th century, it had become clear that any war fought between armies equally equipped with the latest weaponry was simply a bloodbath.



◂ THE BATTLE OF ISANDLWANA
In January, 1879, about 1,500 British soldiers were attacked by a Zulu force outnumbering them ten to one. After losing their field guns early in the action, the British were overrun, and almost all were killed.

"I rejoice to find that the sympathy of **well-nigh the whole world** is on our side in **this struggle for right and liberty**"

STATE PRESIDENT OF THE SOUTH AFRICAN REPUBLIC, PAUL KRUGER, *THE MEMOIRS OF PAUL KRUGER*, 1902

KEY **BATTLE**

THE BATTLE OF ADOWA
1896

Ethiopia was the only African state to retain full independence in the imperialist era. In March 1896, an Italian army invaded Ethiopia from Eritrea, launching an ill-planned attack on King Menelik II's army at Adowa. Losing their cohesion on difficult terrain, the Italian forces were massacred.



▲ A contemporary French magazine featuring King Menelik II, victor of Adowa, on its cover.



◂ A ZULU WARRIOR HUNTING DANCE
The Zulu were a pastoral people in southern Africa. They became a dominant regional power in the early 19th century, through the adoption of a rigorous military organization and effective fighting tactics with the stabbing spear and shield.